decision was made at the insistence of the Kremlin “dove” Anastas Mikoyan, who convinced Nikita Khrushchev to stop the submarines even before Kennedy announced the discovery of Soviet missiles in Cuba.

“Given all that, I proceeded from the premise that the missiles deployed in Cuba had seriously complicated the situation, and that would lead to new complications,” recalled Mikoyan, referring to the surface-to-air missiles—the ballistic missiles were still a secret at the time. “We do not want to fight over that issue,” said Mikoyan, continuing his line of argument. “If our submarines remain at three days’ sailing distance, that does not impair their combat-readiness, but those are not Cuban waters and can have nothing to do with Cuba, and the Americans can undertake nothing against them at that distance.” He indicated the dire consequences of the opposite scenario: “But if they proceed to Cuba under water, then they may be discovered by American submarines, and then there would be a clash between our navy and the American navy, which, given prevailing conditions, would worsen the situation even more and produce a serious conflict.”

Khrushchev was prepared to listen, but Marshal Malinovsky wanted the submarines to remain on course. Two or three members of the Presidium supported Malinovsky, and Mikoyan’s proposal was voted down. He convinced Khrushchev to put it back on the agenda but lost again. “I said that the shores there were shallow and winding, with many islands, and that it would be very difficult to pass unnoticed,” wrote Mikoyan, noting how he had used his firsthand knowledge of Cuban geography in discussion. “Malinovsky maintained his position, although it was apparent that he was incompetent on that question.” Not until Admiral Sergei Gorshkov, the commander in chief of the Soviet Navy, joined the meeting did Mikoyan get his way.

“I asked Gorshkov,” recalled Mikoyan, “ ‘Couldn’t you say where our submarines are, and can they proceed farther?’ Gorshkov showed very clearly on the map where our submarines were located and explained their forward movement. He noted that in one place the submarines would have to make their way through a narrow strait near a small island on which an American base was located. There were locators and other equipment there, and it would be impossible to pass undetected through that strait. He